

DELIVERING DESTRUCTION
A B-2 stealth bomber of the US

had a free run of Iranian skies, bombing at will not just military targets but Revolutionary Guard and police establishments, indicating his intent to engineer regime change. He has now announced that the dual imminent existential threat to Israel, both nuclear and ballistic, has been removed.

Israel's missile defences have also been shown to be vulnerable. Tel Aviv and other cities and iconic institutions have been hit by Iranian missiles. Israelis, though broadly supportive of Netanyahu's attack on Iran, will be thankful that this has not turned into a war of attrition.

At best, this is an uncertain end to the present conflict; military actions are not the solution to complex underlying problems. The lessons of such conflict need to be factored into India's West Asia policy. Around 40 per cent of our oil imports (Iraq, Saudi and UAE) and LNG supplies from Qatar come through the Strait of Hormuz which Iran can close as a desperate measure. Raised shipping and insurance costs for our exports to West Asia and through the Red Sea will impact trade and transportation. The nine million-strong Indian diaspora in the region and their remittances will be at risk. Without political stability, our investment in Iran's Chabahar port is vulnerable, and visions like the I2U2 and the India-Middle East-Europe corridor (IMEC) should be approached with caution. Given our strategic links with the US, Iran and Israel, we will have to walk more than one tightrope in a demonstration of strategic autonomy. But our substantial interests demand that we encourage them all to take the path of dialogue and diplomacy. ■

military campaign against Hamas, earlier seen as justified, is now being viewed less sympathetically and more as Netanyahu wreaking vengeance.

High Stakes for India

For India, the biggest challenge of the continuing unrest in the Middle East is economic. Iran's threat of shutting down the vital Straits of Hormuz had the war continued saw stock markets shiver. Almost 20 per cent of the world's oil and 30 per cent of the global gas supply passes through the Hormuz Straits. With the Gulf nations meeting over 40 per cent of India's oil and gas needs, any disruption in supplies could see petroleum prices rise sharply and wipe out the strides India has made in keeping inflation under 6 per cent. For every $10 increase in oil prices, India has to spend an additional $1 billion (Rs 8,580 crore) in imports. With the country importing over 89 per cent of its oil and gas requirements, India's best-laid economic plans can go haywire and slow down economic growth.

Moreover, 40 per cent of the annual Indian remittances of $129.1 billion (Rs 11.04 lakh crore) in 2024 came from the Gulf Cooperation Council countries, which have 8.9 million Indian expatriates living in the region. That could be seriously hit in case of a conflict there. There is also the emergency evacuation of Indian citizens from conflict zones as was done in Iran. That's why Prime Minister Narendra Modi appealed to Israel and Iran to de-escalate and give more room for dialogue and diplomacy rather than military options.

The other lesson from this conflict as well as from India's own 'Operation Sindoor' is how air superiority and armaments capable of striking from stand-off distances have come to play a dominating role in modern warfare. India, therefore, needs to proactively strengthen its strike capability using precision missiles and unmanned combat vehicles like loitering drones with munitions. However, unlike Iran and Israel, which do not share a border and have 2,000 km separating them, India has common boundaries with Pakistan and China and cannot rely on air power alone. "In India's case," says Gen. Naravane, "all three military domains, whether land, air or sea, have to be given equal importance. And we have to ensure that we have state-of-the-art technology, especially with manned aircraft, tanks and similar large surface combatants likely to become dinosaurs in the 21st century." Even more important is to control the conflict narrative and ensure that international opinion remains favourable. Neither the US and Israel nor Iran have done a good job of it, deepening the unease about the ceasefire being anything but a lasting truce. ■